

Muslim Ethnic Comedy: Inversions of Islamophobia

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I see other minorities and I am jealous. They get a whole month that celebrates their heritage. Black history month, Asian awareness month, Hispanic awareness month. What do we get? We get ORANGE ALERT!

—Dean Obeidallah, comedian and member
of the Axis of Evil comedy troupe

[Little Mosque] is appealing because it shows Muslims being normal. It humanizes Muslims. I want the broader society to look at us as normal, with the same issues and concerns as anyone else.

—Zarqa Nawaz, creator of the TV series
Little Mosque on the Prairie

[By hosting Muslim comedy] we want to demystify the FBI and show people that we are human, not just cold FBI agents coming out to arrest people.

—Gwen Hubbard, chief recruiter for the FBI's
National Recruiting/Testing Office

The association of Muslims with terrorism after 9/11 has prompted a search for the “comic” side of being Muslim. Do these people ever laugh? The simplistic idea that Muslims “hate us” has simultaneously produced rigid stereotypes and a countering desire to discover what those stereotypes deny: among other things, a Muslim sense of humor. Needless to say, in reasoning like this, humor usually stands for humanity. If someone has a sense of humor, then he is just like us: likable. The Danish cartoon crisis shone an uncomfortable spotlight on the Muslim relationship to humor. The degree to which the cartoons were actually funny or offensive, to whom, and for what reasons, is a complicated

subject I will not explore here. Obviously, humor was not the only issue at stake. Rather predictably, however, some Western commentators saw in the Danish cartoon affair a Muslim intolerance of humor, which they equated with cultural inferiority. This kind of shortsightedness has a way of conjuring its opposite. Increasing curiosity about Muslims and their (supposed lack of) humor has created a surprising demand for Muslim ethnic comedy, especially in liberal societies where Muslims have the relative comfort to crack jokes about themselves and their non-Muslim compatriots.

Since the tragic events of 9/11, there has been an upsurge in ethnic comedy by Muslims in America. Individuals like Azhar Usman or Ahmed Ahmed and groups such as Allah Made Me Funny and Axis of Evil are appearing onstage with comic routines. They attract young Muslim audiences but also, increasingly, non-Muslim ones. Paradoxically, a tragedy that triggered widespread Islamophobia in American society seems also to have opened the field for Muslim comedy. This essay explores the intricate relationship between Islamophobia and Muslim ethnic comedy and argues that both phobic and philic sentiments arise from a loss of *common sense*. Muslim ethnic comedy in the United States thus becomes a series of inversions played out against a background of Islamophobia. A journey from fear to laughter, it aims to bridge the divide that separates Muslims from the rest of American society by reaffirming both sides' common humanity.

Muslim Comedy: "The time is right"

Muslim comedy is an emerging "market." Not only is its audience growing, but it is also a new career field for Muslim cultural entrepreneurs, mostly second-generation young people and converts. "The time is right," says Zarqa Nawaz, the Muslim producer of *Little Mosque on the Prairie*, a popular Canadian sitcom. "The marketplace has never been this curious about Muslims." These cultural entrepreneurs claim knowledge of both worlds: ethnic and mainstream. This is best illustrated in their ability to go back and forth between accented and normal speech. As arbiters of a cultural encounter and as field guides to a contact zone, these stand-up comedians are situated in a unique position. Able to "leap" from one side to the other, they practice simultaneously the two ways of seeing things. This position is often a tragic one, where a person belongs to both worlds and neither. The comic stands uneasily on the fault line, yet by standing there he becomes a sort of stitch that holds together the two sides of the cultural rift.

Muslim comedy did not begin with 9/11, but it did take on a distinctive form and quality after it. September 11 is a turning point in the history of American Muslim ethnicity as well as in the history of American Muslim comedy. Like every other ethnic group, the various Muslim communities had their internal humor, their own comedians. But they were completely obscure from the point of view of the larger society. They lacked both common language with and a reputation among mainstream audiences. The members of comedy troupes such as Allah Made Me Funny and Axis of Evil were comedians, but they were not “American Muslim comedians.” They were either obscure ethnic comedians or generic mainstream ones. For example, before his Allah Made Me Funny days, Preacher Moss was producing primarily, but not exclusively, African American humor. Writing for George Lopez and Darrell Hammond, he was a mainstream comedian with an African American edge. As an individual, he was Muslim, but this was not the primary framework defining his work. Similarly, Dean Obeidallah of Axis of Evil repeatedly says that before 9/11 he was a white guy doing generic comedy. After 9/11, he says, he lost his white status and became Arab.

Islamophobia is what has made Muslim comedy a phenomenon of our times. The discrimination, prejudices, and stereotypes from which other Muslims suffer are a godsend for the Muslim comedian. Muslim comics thus represent the experience of most Muslims, but in an inverted way. They are perhaps the only beneficiaries of the *negative charisma* associated with being Muslim.

Fear and Laughter at the Airport

Let us look at the most prominent Muslim comedian in the United States: Azhar Usman. Usman, who, together with Preacher Moss, founded the troupe Allah Made Me Funny, is the very model of a post-9/11 Muslim stand-up comedian, and his jokes about the airport experience are the epitome of today’s emergent Muslim comedy.

My least favorite thing about being a comedian is all the traveling. That’s right. The moment I have to walk into the airport. Heads turn simultaneously. The security . . . [As though speaking into a walkie-talkie] “We got a Mohammad at 4 o’clock.” “Can I see your ID, please?” “We’ll need to do an extra security check.”

Even worse is the moment I have to get onto the plane. That’s right. People are shocked. They are in the middle of a conversation. “So where are you from . . . ?” And then they suddenly see me. [slightly hysterical voice] “Oh my God! I’m gonna die. [desperate whisper into cell phone] Honey, I love you. He is s-o-o hairy.”

[Here Azhar takes a break from the drama and complains to his audience:]

I don't really understand why these people are so scared of me. I don't get it. Just think about it: if I were the crazy Muslim planning to hijack the plane, this is totally not the disguise I would be in [pirouetting his large, bearded self around the stage]. It doesn't exactly slip me under the radar.

[He concludes his flight story with exaggerated relief:]

Of course, once the plane safely lands, they are just looking over smiling. Ha haa ha. I am waiting for one real honest passenger to come up to me at the end of the flight . . . He says, "Excuse me sir, I thought you were gonna kill us. Ha ha. Sorry about that. Ha ha. Remember when you got up to go to bathroom? I was gonna stab you. Ha ha." That's what it feels like these days, man.

This routine provides a perfect illustration of the Muslim airport experience, where the negative charisma of being Muslim assumes full transparency. At the airport, those who have so far (in the city, at the ticket counter, and so on) been treated equally suddenly become suspect. At the internal borders of the nation, they suddenly feel their protected status begin to evaporate. Even those Muslims who do not consider themselves particularly profiled or discriminated against in everyday life suddenly begin to feel uneasy. Strip search and other security rites of passage through the border show them the hard edge of the nation. Here Muslim otherness is revealed in the most conspicuous way. Despite official efforts to present searches at the airports as random, comedians like Dean Obeidallah skeptically ask their Muslim audiences: "Are you selected for random search even when you are dropping a friend at the airport?"

The fear a Muslim inspires is associated with the unpredictability of his behavior. What if he is a terrorist? What if he hijacks the plane? What if he is only pretending to be normal? All these questions that airport authorities ask citizens to consider transform the Muslim passenger in the eyes of his fellow travelers into a source of unpredictability and danger. When a Muslim like Azhar Usman gets onto the plane, faces fall. Danger is imminent. The anxiety ends only when the plane lands. People are almost thankful to the Muslim passenger for not doing what they feared he might. Flying-while-Muslim thus becomes an extremely public event.

A crucial point here is that the airport is where Muslim experience and American mainstream experience meet. Jokes about aviation thus have a remarkable degree of transparency and universality. Muslims and non-Muslims alike can understand and laugh at airport and airplane jokes. They are at once ethnic and national, particular and universal. These jokes represent the comic surface where Muslim and American perspectives intersect most

“dangerously” and with full intelligibility. Jokes about the airport experience thus constitute a significant portion of the repertoire of Muslim comedians today.

FBI’s Most Wanted: Terrorist and Comedian

The Axis of Evil comedy tour started in November 2005 and gained national recognition with an appearance on *Comedy Central* on March 10, 2007. The group also put out a DVD in 2007 which features Maz Jobrani, Ahmed Ahmed, Aron Kader, and guest member Dean Obeidallah.

Ahmed Ahmed is an Egyptian American who also had an acting career in Hollywood. Dissatisfied with the parts available to Middle Eastern actors, he decided to become a stand-up comedian after 9/11. Ahmed’s routine typically revolves around the absurdities of the security check at the airport. He claims that his name matches one of the FBI’s most wanted terrorists. So each time he goes to the airport, he has to go through extra security checks. As he puts it:

It is a bad time to be from the Middle East. I read a statistic on CBS.com. Right after 9/11, hate crimes against Arabs, Middle Eastern people and Muslims went up over 1,000%. Apparently that puts us in the fourth place behind blacks, gays, and Jews. You guys know this? We are still in the fourth place. So what do we have to do to be number one in something?

Ahmed Ahmed notes that often people don’t believe that he is a comedian—especially when it’s the airport security staff asking him what he does for a living. “They always say, ‘So tell us a joke.’ And I go, ‘Well, I just graduated from flight school.’” Once on board, Ahmed looks around the plane. “Do you know who the air marshal is on the plane? The guy reading *People* magazine upside down while keeping an eye on me.”

Otherness: Scary and Funny

The appearance and potential disappearance of ethnic comedy is linked to the location of the ethnic group in relation to the majority society. A minority group has an otherness that can seem indelible as long as the group makes some effort to maintain its distinct identity. Anxiety about identity preservation and the power differential with the majority group can combine to create a sense of “insecurity.” This insecurity—a mismatch between habitus and habitat, to use Bourdieu’s (1977) terms—produces cultural discord and can lead to tragic and comic outcomes. In this sense, both fear and laughter are reactions to otherness.

They represent two directions of destabilization and alienation from everyday rationality. No wonder, then, that people who experience “shocks” (from accidents to earthquakes) are prone to laughter (Brottman 2004: 76).

Discrimination or racism and ethnic comedy are two sides of the same coin. In both cases there is a breakdown—or more precisely, a deroutinization—a certain degree of alienation from common sense. Common sense here refers to a social consensus, a shared vision. The majority knows only its own view of the world, and from its vantage point the minority may look funny. But the minority has access to two visions: the majority vision, which it is obligated to cultivate in order to “fit in”; and its own, particular view. The group with the double vision, the minority, is more likely to see incongruities between the two worldviews and so finds more to laugh at. It is no wonder that many minority groups are historically famous for their humor. Behind the large body of Jewish humor lies the Jewish experience of marginality (Rappoport 2005: 66; Berger 1997: xvii). Minorities—or in our case, immigrant communities—can laugh both at the majority’s taken-for-granted idiosyncrasies and at the majority’s view of the minority, which they find scarily wrong or amusingly incorrect. Anthropologist Mary Douglas (1975) has rightly called humor a “play upon forms.” A form that looks like unassailable truth in the majority view may turn to a tottering fiction in the eyes of the minority. The ethnic comedian basically plays on stereotypes. He critiques and destabilizes the existing “common sense” for its failure to see reality. It comes as no surprise that Aristotle declares, in his *Poetics*, that “the comic poet should assign his characters their ancestral dialect, and himself the local one” (Aristotle 1987: 45). One of Azhar Usman’s airport jokes reflects the discordant vision imposed on Muslims. Dazed by the barrage of announcements warning travelers to “report suspicious individuals,” he finds himself looking over at a corner of the waiting area. “I see this guy. He looks shady. I call the security guy over and he says, ‘You’re looking in a mirror, sir.’”

Comic vision reveals a reality different from commonsense reality. Phenomenological sociologist Alfred Schutz distinguishes between commonsense reality (“the paramount reality of the everyday life”) and other realities (“finite provinces of meaning”) (Schutz 1962: 207). Here, commonsense reality is objective in that it is shared by multiple social actors and is thoroughly sedimented in language and everyday symbolic structures. Other realities, however, remain subjective and partial. The comic presents an alternative reality that transcends the reality of the ordinary and helps us see things from a certain distance. What is crucial here is the relationship between *vision* and *distance*. Those who are in a position to see things differently are more likely to generate humor. Simmel’s

famous social type, the *stranger*, represents this ability to be both near and far and to be able to stay attached to the mainstream vision and withdraw back to the ethnic vision (Simmel 1971: 143–48).

Muslim comedians find themselves on a borderline where they can criticize both the majority and their own minority communities. “We are not a politically active community,” observes Azhar Usman. “We have conference after conference about what? ‘Muslim participation in the political process.’ At every one a Desi uncle stands up and says: ‘We need more Muslims in politics. We need Muslim politicians and journalists.’ Then you ask him, ‘Hey, uncle, you have three children, what do they do?’ He says, ‘Mashaallah, they are all doctors. I am so proud of them—even though one of them had to go to the Caribbean to get a degree.’”

“Any Syrians in the audience?” Usman often asks. “You know, I have a Syrian friend. Blond hair, blue eyes: totally blends into corporate America. Then one year he goes to the holiday party with his wife, who wears hijab. He’s outed. ‘Oh my God,’ one of his co-workers says, ‘I thought he was Jewish. I’ve been sending him Hanukkah cards for the past ten years.’”

As an African American Muslim, Preacher Moss is particularly well placed to comment on community divisions. “You know, I’m married to an Indian sister,” he mentions in his routine, usually to applause from the audience. “All those people out there clapping,” he immediately adds, “I know you’re thinking: ‘Thank God it’s not my sister!’”

Theories of the Comic

As a uniquely human phenomenon, humor has been an object of curiosity for philosophers. Among the oldest accounts of why we laugh is the theory of superiority. According to this approach, propounded by Plato, Aristotle, and later Hobbes, we laugh at our inferiors. Laughter is seen as a means of expressing superiority over other people. Such laughter can be aggressive and is certainly self-celebratory. For our purposes here, the main insight of the superiority theory of humor is the idea of *relationality*. Superiority theory acknowledges both the power differential and the relation between two parties.

If superiority theory is a political explanation of the comic, incongruity theory provides a rather cultural one. It sees humor as an outcome of inconsistent, unexpected acts and conditions. For example, Pascal, one of the early proponents of this view, argues that “nothing produces laughter more than a surprising disproportion between that which one expects and that which one sees” (Morreal 1983: 16). Similarly, Schopenhauer describes laughter as happen-

ing in situations marked by “the sudden perception of incongruity between a concept and things themselves” (Schopenhauer 1966: 91). As Morreal puts it, summarizing Schopenhauer’s perspective, “What causes laughter is a mismatch between conceptual understanding and perception” (Morreal 1983: 18). Here a concept is general and lumps together unique and particular things as if they were identical instantiations of that concept. (And isn’t this the perfect definition of a stereotype?) All concepts do violence to the uniqueness of the things they claim to represent: this is a problem intrinsic to any abstraction (Nietzsche 2006: 117; Simmel 1950: 63). This violence cries out for refutation or rectification. One way to cure it is through comic treatment. Laughter, one may argue, is a product of the sudden recognition of this very gap. In this accidental encounter between reality or experience (minority vision) and the abstract metaphysics of stereotypes (majority vision), an everyday version of the destruction of metaphysics (what Derrida [1998] calls *deconstruction*) takes place. After all, what is comedy but a comic deconstruction?

Another prominent theory of humor is called the relief theory. Relief theory emphasizes the cathartic release from repression: in Aristotelian terms, a “purification” of emotions. In *Civilization and Its Discontents*, Freud explores the psychic cost of civilization for individuals. He identifies the overwhelming power and expansion of the *reality principle* over the *pleasure principle* as the main cause for the unhappiness of modern man (Freud 1961: 22). In comedy the relationship is reversed. We revert to the pleasure principle, albeit temporarily. In his discussion of jokes, Freud also links jokes to the unconscious and draws attention to the economy of psychic energy in the repression of emotions (the id) by the superego. Freud argues that the “manifest content of dreams and jokes yield pleasure through their disguised expression of unconscious wishes, resulting in partial lifting of repression and an economic expenditure of psychic energy” (quoted in Bergmann 1999: 3).

Mary Douglas (1975) and Victor Turner (1969), two prominent cultural anthropologists working within the Durkheimian tradition, rightly point to the margins and to liminality as the location of humor. Comedy is an anti-rite presented in a ritual, an anti-structure imagined as an alternative structure. Comedy, they claim, turns the world upside down by showing the audience the view from the other side. The majority’s vision (structure) is temporarily and imaginarily relegated to the status of anti-structure, while the minority’s vision (anti-structure) is elevated in its place. In this reversal of symbolic order, the minority is released from social classifications (e.g., stereotypes), and the majority is given the opportunity to feel like a minority (Douglas 1975: 103; Berger 1997: 72).

The idea of a reversal of symbolic order is of crucial importance for understanding the structural dimensions of ethnic comedy. Often perceived as a reversal of the relationship between the rational and the irrational, comic vision does indeed thrive on the discrepancies and interplay of two forces. For Nietzsche, these two forces were the Apollonian and Dionysian principles. The former is associated with structure, rationality, and seriousness and the latter with anti-structure, emotions, and laughter. Both comedy and tragedy originated in the cult of Dionysus, the Greek god of revelry and excess who violates all ordinary boundaries. This is why comedy is perceived as a threat to the established order—and Plato in his *Republic* famously calls for the banishment of poets (i.e., comedians and tragedians) from the ideal city.

This Dionysian element in the Greek tradition is continued by the Roman festival of Saturnalia (Nietzsche 2006: 122) and extends into the present day in the many versions of Carnival. Mikhail Bakhtin famously observed that in carnivals and other rites of passage, the ordinary world is turned upside down (Bakhtin 1968; Brottman 2004: 150; Berger 1997: 21). Laughter is therefore “one of the essential forms of truth concerning the world as a whole. . . . It is a peculiar point of view relative to the world. . . . Certain essential aspects of the world are accessible only to laughter” (Bakhtin 1968: 20).

Baber at the Bakhtinian Carnival

One episode of *Little Mosque* focuses on Baber, a protective father who is reluctant to let his daughter dress up and go trick-or-treating at Halloween. He finally decides to let her go, but only if he goes with her. So the little girl in her costume sets out with her bearded father in the religiously conservative Pakistani dress that he wears every day. But the neighborhood children greet him with shouts of “Great costume!” They think he’s dressed up as Osama bin Laden. In a carnivalesque moment, the festivity that Baber had thought was foreign to his culture and potentially harmful for his children suddenly turns around and embraces him: by cultural accident, an awkward-looking immigrant guy becomes a local dressed strangely for Halloween. The carnival, according to Bakhtin, is the time and place where the world is turned upside down. Just so, it temporarily releases Baber from the tension of being his usual, strange self. For once he feels comfortable in his exotic outfit and joins his daughter in playful celebration of Halloween. Halloween becomes Halal-oween. He almost reverts to the unselfconscious pleasures of childhood, horsing around with the other kids and competing to see who can get the most candy. For a brief time the abnormal, exotic has become the normal, familiar. He feels relieved.

In this segment we see Baber oscillating between fear and laughter. The phobic and philic destinations mark the two extremes toward which he finds himself thrown. What is common to both conditions is their distance or alienation from reason/normality. It is as if he sinks below the level of commonsense rationality through fear (What is this Halloween, anyway? Can my daughter join in this pagan festival and still be a good Muslim?), and then rises above it through laughter. Once the balance is lost, it is much easier to go from fear to laughter than back to reason. There is a reason for that: while fear and reason belong to different spheres, fear and laughter (or pity, or love) share the same world of emotions. To restore reason, one emotion has to be undone by another emotion. This process of undoing the fall from reason requires catharsis (purification, purging of negative emotions). A bit of laughter can undo your fears and bring you back into the fold of rationality. This is the therapeutic function of comedy (and tragedy) that Aristotle argued for in his *Poetics*. Both tragedy and comedy, the philosopher argues, have a cathartic effect. They purify the soul and restore the balance of reason (Aristotle 1987: 45).

The FBI and Muslim Comedy

Widespread public Islamophobia and the government crackdown on Muslim institutions and individuals have deepened the alienation of Muslims from security agencies such as the FBI. In response to this problem, the FBI recently initiated an outreach program targeting Muslims. Thousands of Muslims who attended the annual convention of the Islamic Society of North America (ISNA) in south Chicago in 2007 came across an FBI booth in the bazaar section of the convention. The signs at the booth read, "Today's FBI: It's for You." Efforts to build bridges with the Muslim community in general and Arabs in particular were taken to another level when the FBI sponsored a performance by Axis of Evil at an American-Arab Anti-Discrimination Committee (ADC) convention in Washington, D.C. In an interview with Reuters explaining the rationale behind the FBI's use of ethnic comedians to reach out to suspicious Arabs and Muslims, Gwen Hubbard, the chief recruiter for the agency, said: "We want to demystify the FBI and show people that we are human, not just cold FBI agents coming out to arrest people" (www.IslamOnline.net, June 14, 2007).

The FBI's rationale for hosting Muslim comedians is strikingly similar to Muslims' own approach to comedy. When Zarqa Nawaz, the creator of the television series *Little Mosque on the Prairie*, gave a talk in Detroit, she said "[*Little Mosque*] is appealing because it shows Muslims being normal. It hu-

manizes Muslims. I want the broader society to look at us as normal, with the same issues and concerns as anyone else.”

The gulf opened between the two sides by the tragic events of 9/11 and subsequent arrests and surveillance of Muslims has disrupted the balance of rationality and citizenship. A gap has appeared between appearance and reality. From each side, one can easily become suspicious of the other. What if they are terrorists pretending to be decent citizens? What if they are after us no matter what decent citizens we are? Both sides harbor (ungrounded?) fears when it comes to the other. To pull each other out of fear back into the sphere of rationality (common sense, a sense that is common to both), they have to go through laughter. Laughter allows each to see the world through the eyes of the other. Since they no longer share a common view of the world, their redemption is possible only through putting themselves in each other's shoes. That is precisely what the Muslim comic does: he undermines the two sides' discordant visions by playing on them, making them explicit. “The comic invades and subverts the taken-for-granted structures of social life” (Berger 1997: 91).

A terrorist masquerading as a citizen versus a citizen masquerading as a terrorist. These are the FBI's bugbears and the butt of the Muslim comedian's jokes. It is as though Muslim comics engage in a game of cultural peekaboo by transmuting phobic suspicions into surprised exclamations of “Oh, he is one of us after all.”

The Inverted World of Muslim Comedy

Comedy constructs a counter-world to the world of ordinary life. Because the everyday world has become extraordinary, the Muslim (an oddity in American life) becomes funny when he appears “ordinary.” In other words, humor allows for a distortion of commonsense reality. Those whose reality is already distorted because of stereotypes resort to humor to rectify and reassert their own sense of what is real.

One sees a series of inversions in the practice of Muslim ethnic comedy. Let us start with some rather trivial ones. When Maz Jobrani of Axis of Evil picks up a digital video camera at the ADC convention and starts to record the FBI agents sitting around the table close to the stage, he is engaged in a symbolic reversal of the wiretapping and surveillance of Muslims by the FBI. Muslim actors like Jobrani who found no roles in Hollywood but those of terrorists switched to stand-up comedy—where they now mock the very roles they once played. Of course, this reversal of symbolic structure is not itself irreversible. Muslims tend to think that shows like *Little Mosque* are bastions of Islamophilia

in a sea of hostile media, but then are surprised to discover that the actor who plays Yasir, one of the central characters, went on to play the role of a terrorist on the rather Islamophobic television series 24.

The demands of comedy may even force performers to raise their “Muslim quotient.” Tissa Hami, an Iranian American comedian from Boston, who normally does not wear hijab, onstage wears an Iranian chador (a voluminous black cloak that covers her from head to toe). Sometimes she wears a slightly less full hijab—if, she jokes, she is feeling “slutty.” About airport security and full body searches she notes wryly: “I was kind of hoping to save that for the honeymoon.”

The discrepancy between the reality of the Muslim community and the stereotypes about it continues to be a source of concern and humor. On closer inspection one sees that the latter is an inversion of the former. An interesting outcome of the securitization of society is the ban on jokes at the airport. Making jokes in the security check area at the airport is strictly prohibited and punishable by law. According to a statement released on March 11, 2004, by the TSA (Transportation Security Agency), a woman was jailed for joking about bombs in her luggage. This particular ban makes airports a unique part of the national space. Airports are internal borders. As entry and exit points to the nation, airports provide us a unique perspective on questions of sovereignty and identity. The enforcement of no-joke zones at the airports after the tragedy of 9/11 is thus indicative of the paradoxical connection between the tragic and the comic.

An equally interesting development is the attempt on the part of Muslim ethnic comedians to turn the stage into a symbolic airport space. They do so not only by drawing much of their material from their experiences at the airport but also by literally entering the stage in a mock ritual (anti-rite) of passing through a scanner and being searched by mock TSA staff. Axis of Evil’s famous performance on *Comedy Central* is the best example: they perform on a stage festooned with nuclear warning signs and each comedian is frisked by a tough-looking female security screener in full TSA regalia as he steps onto the stage. They are not the only ones to use this gimmick. In one of his performances with comedian Rabbi Bob Alper, Azhar Usman and Alper patted one another down as they took turns at the microphone. (The two comedians have toured together across the country, doing shows on college campuses and at Muslim and Jewish religious centers.)

The turning of airports into no-joke zones and the turning of the Muslim comic zone into a symbolic airport are two expressions of a single undercurrent. They are also symptomatic of the Dionysian continuum of fear and laughter,

or the existential continuity between insecurity and relief. What links the no-joke zone to the comic stage is what links the tragedy of 9/11 to the emergence of Muslim comedy.

Muslim comedy is a form of code-switching in the face of situations where the language of reason is overtaken by a wrong common sense or common wrong sense. Muslim comedy reveals the space of otherness that stretches between looking scary and looking funny. By undoing otherness, Muslim ethnic comedy lifts, albeit temporarily, the restrictive limits on the self and abolishes the gulf that separates the Muslim minority from the American mainstream. It provides a relief from social classifications (a.k.a. stereotypes), which are often oppressive of the minority group. It redefines the common sense. The ability of comedy to disclose the rock bottom of our identities as “human” plays a significant role in showing the commonalities beneath the surface of “difference.” That comedy reveals our humanity is well illustrated by a comment from Jewish comic Rabbi Bob Alper, who observed after a performance with Azhar Usman in Detroit on April 1, 2008, “You can’t hate the person you’ve laughed with.” Usman recalls hearing a similar sentiment from a non-Muslim audience member: “I didn’t see you as a Muslim, I saw you as a human being.”

Muslim ethnic comedy is part of the Americanization process: the power of comedy becomes a means of undoing otherness. The comic vision rehumanizes Muslims and allows comedians to engage in a symbolic reversal of the social order. Muslim ethnic comedy is the world of Islamophobia turned upside down.

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Competing for Muslims: New Strategies for Urban Renewal in Detroit

Sally Howell

Masjid Mu'ath bin Jabal is a Yemeni mosque located in Detroit, on the outskirts of Hamtramck, a working-class, historically Polish city that is bounded on all sides by Detroit and isolated further by a ring of industrial factories and freeways. Masjid Mu'ath bin Jabal has been credited (by local Muslims and public officials alike) with having turned around one of Detroit's roughest neighborhoods at the height of the crack cocaine epidemic of the 1980s, making its streets safe, revitalizing a dormant housing market, attracting new business to the area, and laying the foundation for an ethnically mixed, highly visible Muslim population in Detroit and Hamtramck. In 1990, Mu'ath bin Jabal was the only mosque in this neighborhood. Today, it is the largest of ten mosques within a three-mile radius.

In 2005, the Muslims of Hamtramck were very much in the local, national, and even international news. One of the city's newer mosques, Al-Islah Jamee Masjid, a Bengali house of worship, had requested permission from the city to broadcast its *idhan*, or call to prayer, from loudspeakers outside the mosque. This request brought to a head simmering Islamophobic sentiments in the city, attracted anti-Muslim activists from as far away as Ohio and Kentucky, and gave the rest of the United States (via an international media storm) a cathartic test of the "freedoms" we were said to be "fighting for" in Afghanistan and Iraq. Local Muslim and interfaith activists rallied around the mosque, as did city voters, support which helped pull Hamtramck's Muslims out of their immigrant parochialism and into the fray of city politics.¹ At the height of the media frenzy surrounding Hamtramck's *idhan* controversy, a story appeared